Signals for Next Season

Juhan Youn | 2027 hitter assessment | Executive summary | Corrected 2026-10-04

Question and decision

Do current underlying skills and annual changes improve next-season batting forecasts and breakout-retention assessment beyond traditional results? The practical decision is how to allocate limited hitter-review time after the season ends.

Main finding

Current skill levels improved observed retention discrimination, but annual changes added small and inconsistent gains. The signal-screen policy produced fewer historical growth successes than M1-only selection. Retain M1 as the forecast reference and treat the five signal candidates as exploratory investigation hypotheses.

Design and forecast error

Savant 2015-2026; expanding target-year evaluations for 2022-2026. M1 uses traditional results; M2 adds skill levels; M3 adds changes. Ridge alpha=10. Eligible input: PA >=200 and prior PA >=100. Forecast-error evaluation conditions on next-season PA >=200.

Period	M1 RMSE	M2 RMSE	M3 RMSE
2022-2025	.03201	.03185	.03168
Most recent year: 2026	.03075	.02972	.02980

M3 did not pass the adoption rule. M2's development MAE was slightly higher than M1's at the fixed alpha=10. The observed 2026 comparison informed selection and is not independent validation.

Same-budget growth success

Policy	Slots	Screen then M1	M1-only	Random expected
Original screen	53	7	13	11.20
Revised screen	22	2	7	5.18

Growth success = next-season PA >=200 and wOBA increase >=.020. Insufficient PA counts as failure. Retention AUC answers a different question from top-k growth yield. These observed comparisons are exploratory.

Five 2027 investigation hypotheses

Hitter	2026 wOBA	xwOBA	xwOBA change	2027 M1
Heriberto Hernández	.329	.347	+.016	.329
Lawrence Butler	.319	.326	+.021	.324
Spencer Steer	.325	.342	+.049	.322
Lars Nootbaar	.320	.343	+.026	.321
Tyler Stephenson	.320	.326	+.015	.312

Nootbaar's 334PA followed injury recovery and a midseason trade; health and within-season consistency require review. The display order follows M1 and does not establish an optimal scouting priority.

Prospective check and limits

All 298 forecasts and evaluation rules are frozen; 2027 outcomes remain pending. Annual data do not test earlier within-season detection or causality. Player availability, repeated hitters, few years, and historical data revisions limit inference. No acquisition ROI or market undervaluation is estimated.